

Action Plan CoARA 2024-2027
ZonMw and NWO

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Authors (in alphabetical order by surname) Robert Jabroer, Hans de Jonge, Daphne
Kortbeek, Tamara van Mólken, Eline
Pronk, Sarah Steendam, Jeroen
Sondervan, Marta Teperek, Ingrid van
Tienen, Thecla van Wageningen, Helga
Varwijk, Sanneke van Vliet

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Introduction

The Netherlands Organisation for Health Research and development ([ZonMw](#)), a research funding organisation, and the Dutch Research Council ([NWO](#)), a research funding and research performing organisation, have been actively working on the reform of their research assessment within the National Recognition and Rewards programme. In December 2019, the position paper '[Room for Everyone's Talent](#): towards a new balance in the recognition and rewards for academics' was published by the Universities of the Netherlands (UNL), the Netherlands Federation of University Medical Centres (NFU), the Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts & Sciences (KNAW), NWO and ZonMW. To put the priorities from the position paper into practice, a [road map](#) was designed at the end of 2023. The objectives of this national program are:

- Diversification and vitalisation of career paths;
- Achieving balance between individuals and the collective;
- Focusing on quality;
- Stimulating all aspects of open science;
- Encouraging academic leadership.

In 2022 ZonMw and NWO signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) and joined the Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment. By signing, our organisations continue their efforts for the reform of Research Assessment in an international context. The goals of this reform movement are largely in line with the goals set in the national Recognition and Rewards programme. This means that we have already made several changes to our research assessment, that help meet the goals set in the CoARA commitments.

In this action plan, we outline future practices and activities as well as those that have already been embedded within our organisations. This plan reflects and features the dual role of NWO as both a research funding and research performing organisation (through the ten research institutes that are under the umbrella of the NWO organisation). As our organisations are actively working together, this plan reflects on practices and activities in both our organisations and that are carried out within the four domains (*Science, Social Sciences and Humanities, Applied and Engineering Sciences and Medical Sciences (ZonMW)*), the four Taskforces (*Dutch Climate Research Initiative - KIN, Netherlands Initiative for Education Research - NRO, Open Science NL - OSNL and the Taskforce for Applied Research - SIA*) and the ten research institutes (*NWO-I*). We hope this plan leads to mutual learning and inspiration and shows our continued support for this important movement.

Action Plan

The section below describes the current state towards the implementation of the [ARRA Commitments](#), as well as planned future actions.

Commitment	Current state	Actions
1: Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Evidence-based CV has been introduced for all individual grants. It consists of two parts: a narrative academic profile and a list of key-output. The narrative academic profile allows applicants to highlight their own academic achievements without being limited by prescribed questions. Applicants are asked to highlight their most relevant academic abilities and achievements, and to provide context and evidence of how these elements demonstrate their academic qualities. In the key-output section applicants are requested to list and provide context for up to 10 outputs that best demonstrate their qualities, and that are relevant to the application, their own and/or other scientific fields, the research idea and/or society. A broad definition of output is used, and applicants can list both more "traditional" output items such as scholarly articles and more "non-traditional" outputs, such as datasets, exhibitions, visual media, patents and software. To reduce gender bias in the assessment procedure, within the pre-application phase of the Talent schemes, applicants are instructed not to use any first names or pronouns in the application. This information is only listed in the database which is not visible for the reviewers.	NWO and ZonMW will: - look into enabling of the reporting of diverse research outputs in its future grants management system, which is currently being developed. - revise their Research Data Management policy to make it more inclusive of other research outputs. - investigate the possibilities of enabling support staff to be part of paid research teams in grant proposals. The Taskforce for Applied Research (SIA) will investigate the use of the evidence-based CV for specific (if/when applicable) grant applications from universities of applied sciences. NWO is committed to the further development, implementation and funding of Open Research Europe (ORE) publishing service, which supports publishing of research articles and 13 other types of publications (including methods, software tools, study protocols, and case reports).

	As the time researchers can spend on research is important and differs based on individual contracts, within the individual grant applications, applicants are asked to give an estimate of their effective research time. The assessment committee is requested to take this contextual information into account when assessing the evidence-based CV. NWO has developed two instruction videos on the <u>inclusive assessment</u> of diverse career paths. The videos are intended for reviewers and committee members involved in the evaluation process and provide information about implicit bias and the (often limited) image of what is a good researcher or a good proposal. For funded projects applicants are requested, during and after the project phase, to not only report on output such as scholarly articles but to also include other research results/output such as datasets, software, workflows, protocols, prototypes, intellectual property rights, and standards. NWO provided funding for the establishment of <u>Publinova</u>, an online platform which increases the impact and visibility of research results and outputs from practice-oriented research. NWO is supporting and hosting <u>Open Science NL</u>, which is the national programme that aims to promote and accelerate the transition to open science in the Netherlands.	NWO actively participates in the CoARA Working Group <u>Towards Transformations: Transdisciplinarity, Applied/Practice-Based Research, and Impacts</u> and will actively participate in the National Expertise Centre for Transdisciplinary Work (<u>NECTR</u>) to exchange information and support consortium development for transdisciplinary research, recognizing outputs involving different (research) stakeholders. NWO-I will work towards more formalized time-for-time compensation for non-traditional research outputs.
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	NWO has increased the possibilities for funding for multidisciplinary research by consortia and team science through the Dutch Research Agenda and the Knowledge and Innovation Covenant (KIC). NWO and ZonMw signed the Amsterdam Declaration on Funding Research Software Sustainability (ADORE) with the commitment to include research software in open science policies and to strengthen cooperation with other organisations in this area.	
2: Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	NWO and ZonMw's grant award procedures have always been based on robust qualitative assessments with a clear focus on peer-review. Our organisations make use of (broad) assessment committees and/or external reviewers and, if applicable, reviews from industry and professional stakeholders in the assessment of the applications within our grant award procedures. Moreover, quantitative indicators have never played a formal role in these procedures. Following the signing of the DORA declaration, NWO and ZonMw gradually introduced an evidence-based CV (formerly narrative cv) for all individual grants which allows for a more qualitative assessment of applicants and a further reduction of the uncritical use of (quantitative) bibliometric indicators. NWO and ZonMw support applicants in the responsible use of quantitative indicators by giving a wide variety of examples of indicators that can be used in the evidence-based CV and provides instructions on including substantiation.	The evaluation of the evidence-based CV and promoting the importance of qualitative evaluation in research assessment will be included in the programme evaluation of the NWO talent programme (Veni, Vidi, Vici scheme), which offers individual grants to talented researchers. NWO-I will work towards setting standards for hiring and promotion committees.

	NWO is a member of the Peer Exchange Platform for Narrative-style CVs (PEP-CV), which promotes experience sharing and best practices in the implementation of narrative-style CVs.	
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	NWO and ZonMw have signed the DORA declaration and as a result have implemented the following measures: - Removal of all quality indicators that do not relate to a single output item, such as references to Journal Impact Factors and the h-index, in all call texts and application forms. - Actively informing applicants, referees and committee members about the policy changes that follow from the signing of DORA. - Introduction of the evidence-based CV (formerly narrative CV). Within Taskforce SIA, above measures have already been implemented, as these types of metrics are not used in practice-based research. NWO-I has avoided use of publication-based metrics in their research evaluation in 2023.	NWO and ZonMW will monitor and evaluate previous actions. NWO and ZonMW are committed to Open Research Europe, where each article has a dedicated page of article-level metrics.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Within NWO and ZonMW grant application the use or mention of rankings of research organisations is not allowed and rankings of research organisations are not used in the assessment of research proposals.	
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed	NWO and ZonMw have two joined project groups: - Overseeing the institutional commitment to Recognition and Rewards.	NWO and ZonMW intend to investigate the possibility of introducing the assessment of open science practices within scientific quality criteria of research proposals.

to achieve the organisational changes committed to	- Overseeing the institutional commitment to Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion. An NWO colleague is member of the COARA Steering Board. Both NWO and ZonMw are actively participating in several COARA working groups. The Open Science NL programme, which is hosted by NWO, funded national efforts to coordinate and exchange best practices for embedding open science in institutional hiring and promotion policies. At Taskforce SIA there is a programme dedicated to the further development and strengthening the profession and the field of practice-based research.	
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	NWO is the co-owner of the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP), which provides a framework for research evaluation of the Dutch universities and the research institutes of NWO and KNAW. NWO took an active role in revisions of the protocol, which led to creation of the current SEP 2021-2027. Aspects such as Open Science and Academic Culture are embedded within that protocol. Taskforce SIA was involved in the actualisation of equivalent of SEP at universities of applied sciences: BKO (<i>Brancheprotocol Kwaliteitszorg Onderzoek</i> in Dutch; <i>Sector Protocol for Quality Assurance in Research</i> in English) and has played an active role in	NWO and ZonMW are planning to evaluate the Evidence-Based CV. NWO and ZonMw are committed to evaluating internal review procedures concerning assessment criteria. NWO is actively involved in mid-term evaluation of the Strategy Evaluation Protocol, with the aim to further embed the COARA commitments, including open science. NWO will review its Research Data Management policy in 2025 and will investigate the possibility to embed the evaluation of open science practices in grant proposals as part of the process.

	the connection between BKO and SPRONG principles (SIA financing scheme).	
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	There is an ongoing cycle of communication around COARA and Recognition & Rewards within ZonMw and NWO. NWO and ZonMW train their assessment committees on assessment criteria and inclusive assessment and are continuously working on the development of call assessment guideline documents for the assessment committee, referees and applicants (including guidance on how to assess evidence-based CV). NWO actively contributes (workshops, talks etc) to the yearly national Recognition and Rewards festival. NWO regularly shares awareness raising posts on the open science blog.	NWO and ZonMW intend to continue their current activities. NWO and ZonMW intend to raise more awareness concerning research assessment reform within the organisations, including the practices of research assessment at Universities of Applied Science/ Taskforce SIA. NWO-I will provide a leadership programme which features tools for a new way of research assessment.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	ZonMw and NWO are active members of the national Recognition and Rewards programme, take active parts in national events, and contribute to discussions on the national forum for recognition and rewards (online platform RRview). NWO is a member of the Peer Exchange Platform for Narrative-style CVs (PEP-CV), which promotes experience sharing and best practices in the implementation of narrative-style CVs.	NWO and ZonMW intend to continue their current activities. NWO and ZonMW are involved in the establishment of the COARA National Chapter. Taskforce SIA intends to exchange visits with colleagues from universities of applied sciences.

	NWO is an active member of Science Europe and is involved in several working groups where practices and experiences are exchanged, and the discussion on research assessment among funders are stimulated. The president of NWO is the vice-president of Science Europe (November 2023 – November 2025). NWO is a member of the European Open Science Cloud (EOSC) Association. NWO colleagues have been regularly participating in bilateral discussions with colleagues from other countries about various aspects pertaining to reforming research assessment, such as open science implementation in hiring and promotion criteria. NWO is actively participating in various UNESCO activities (workshops, events), in particular concerning open science aspects of research assessment.	
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments	ZonMw and NWO are active members of the national Recognition and Rewards programme, take active parts in national events, and contribute to discussions on the national forum for recognition and rewards (RRview).	ZonMw and NWO will share this action plan on Zenodo.
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the	ZonMw and NWO are actively involved in its own Research on Research programme, and within that programme, are committed to several projects concerning research evaluation.	NWO and ZonMW intend to continue their current activities.

state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	NWO provides funding for several crucial infrastructures which are essential for providing open and transparent data (e.g., ORCID, ROR, etc.) to support research assessment (https://www.nwo.nl/en/open-science-infrastructure-support). NWO is member of the Global Research Initiative on Open Science (GRIOS, which supports meta-research on open science to help funders, research organisations, and policymakers enhance efficiency and maximise the impact of their open science strategies. Open Science NL has committed 17.5M EUR to building and sustaining open science infrastructures in years 2024-2025. ZonMw and NWO publish regular reports on monitoring open access to publishing and recently also investigated the practices of publishing of research data and software as a result of its funding. All data and software underpinning these reports are openly available. To support transparent and sustainable research assessment, NWO implemented GrantIDs. NWO is partner of the Research-on-Research Institute (RoRi) and, as part of that partnership, is committed to several research-on-research projects.	NWO is involved in five RoRi projects regarding the narrative CV and trans- and interdisciplinary research. NWO intends to develop tools for enabling such evaluation, including enabling the reporting and monitoring the impact of diverse types of research outputs. NWO and ZonMW are planning to evaluate the Evidence-Based CV. NWO-I is establishing a ‘to measure is to know’ approach to policy change.
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